The Forgotten Division
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The Forgotten Division

A resource neglected

by 2ndLt Alexander M. Corbett, USMCR

The SMCR (Selected Marine Corps Reserve) currently has a retention rate of 20 percent after a Marine's first enlistment ends. This creates a shortage of corporals and sergeants. This shortage of NCOs forces lance corporals and other junior Marines to fill billets generally suited to Marines with greater experience. This further decreases unit readiness as SMCR units are often unable to reach desired levels of combat effectiveness without significant predeployment workups to prepare junior Marines to fill billets generally filled by Marines of a higher grade.

A standard table of organization for an infantry battalion, whether Active or Reserve Component, has corporals as fire team leaders, and sergeants as squad leaders. These NCOs lead their lance corporals and other junior Marines, providing mentorship, guidance, and instruction on proficiency in their MOS as well as how to conduct themselves as Marines. Without them, a critical gap exists in the chain of command, and lance corporals are deprived of an NCO working alongside them in order to set the example and give junior Marines a figure they can strive to emulate.

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It is during their second enlistment that most Marines gain experience as corporals pick up sergeant, and the current low retention rate creates a dearth in the number of corporals and sergeants in the SMCR.

A poll conducted of Marines intending to check out of an SMCR rifle company revealed that a lack of operational experience and deployments is the main reason behind low retention rates. SMCR Marines lose motivation because they do not have the opportunity to deploy, attend schools, and do things that they joined the Marine Corps to accomplish.

Currently the time between deployments for an SMCR battalion is over 6 years. This means that Marines can check into a rifle company and spend their whole first enlistment without deploying. NCOs, faced with the prospect that they will not be able to deploy again for several more years, look to other Services in order to satisfy military career goals.

Without operational experience, SMCR Marines lose relevance. Unable to connect what they have learned and trained to do, and never having participated in what they signed up to do in the first place, they lose confidence in why they continue to drill at all. As their expectation of what they would be accomplishing conflicts so greatly with reality, many SMCR Marines choose to leave the organization; thus, retention suffers tremendously.

Currently the Active Component is facing personnel cuts that threaten to reduce the Marine Corps' ability to provide crisis response forces, and make us unable to execute the missions the President needs us to do. This personnel shortage in the Active Component could easily be buttressed by increasing the number of deployments Reservists are asked to do, increasing Marine



Use the Reserve Component more often. Reduce their dwell time in order to maintain their combat efficiency and effectiveness. *(Photo by GySgt Rome M. Lazarus.)*

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4th Battalion, 14th Marines provided supporting fires during the Second Battle of Fallujah, November 2004. (Photo by LCpl Samantha L. Jones.)

Corps combat readiness organization-wide.

In summary, the Reserve Component's long dwell time between deployments is not conducive to mission success for the Marine Corps as a whole. It creates long, repetitive yearly training cycles, with no opportunity in sight for Marines to execute what they have trained for. This has a substantial impact on the combat readiness of the Reserve Component, as low retention rates create a deficit of NCOs and directly affects combat readiness. In order to maintain readiness and improve retention, SMCR units must be used operationally more frequently. Potential solutions to this dilemma include:

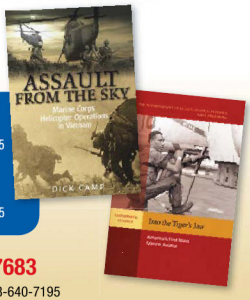
- Decrease dwell time between SMCR deployments to 2 to 3 years. This gives SMCR Marines plenty of time to train, while also providing a target to reach. Allowing Marines to go do the things they signed up to do will raise morale and increase retention, as well as increase the cumulative experience level of SMCR units, creating a more relevant and responsive 4th MarDiv.
- Allow more seats at schools for Reservists. This will allow SMCR Marines to bring knowledge back to their units and increase overall readiness. It will also provide incentive for Marines to stay in. They can look forward to interesting and varied training opportunities.
- Streamline the individual augmentee process for deployments. This will allow Marines to deploy and bring that experience back to their battalion, making for more well-rounded, experienced units. As an added benefit, deploying units will be fully up to their table of organization, enhancing their readiness as well. There should be one dedicated telephone number/point of contact that Marines can access in order to augment. Replace the convoluted way things are today in which even field grade officers do not actually know how the individual augmentee system works nor how to find out about openings on deployments.

With intentional, planned actions, the Marine Corps can easily continue to execute the missions the President directs, and still trim down on manpower. Incorporating the SMCR into future personnel planning in a way previously unseen will alleviate short dwell times for active duty Marines, and will increase retention and readiness in SMCR units. The 4th MarDiv will no longer be the "break glass in case of emergency" division, but will be a relevant, ready fighting force that our adversaries will acknowledge as prepared and professional.

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